

University of Warwick - Warwick Business School

IB845B – Marketing Through Social Media
Individual Assignment

Rolex Vs TAG Heuer : A Comparative Analysis

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Introduction

Rolex and Tag Heuer are both excellent examples of how modern luxury brands use different marketing techniques to reach their target customers. However, these luxury watch brands differ widely with regard to their social media marketing strategies. Rolex builds customer desire through a measured, restrained manner, while Tag Heuer pursues a more aggressive approach to digital growth utilizing a partnership with Formula 1 to build on LVMH's history of creating iconic luxury brands (Digital Luxury Group., 2025). The success of these two brands provides an opportunity for comparative analysis, as they both operate within the same industry but represent nearly opposite sides of the continuum of accessibility vs. exclusivity.

1. Social Media Approaches

1.1 Rolex: The Strategy of Resonance Over Reach

Rolex has been active on every other social media platform other than TikTok. The company has an Instagram account with 18 million followers and only 1,790 posts, which is a relatively low posting cadence compared to other brands but receives a lot of engagement for each post. This fact communicates to followers that exclusivity is part of the brand's overall philosophy.

The content on Rolex's Instagram account is almost entirely cinematic; the videos are either slow-motion watch mechanisms, long shots of similar events (Wimbledon, Le Mans, Augusta), or tight close-ups of ambassadors of Rolex. No memes, trending audio, or reposts of users are present on the account at all. There are no giveaways, polls, or "swipe up to shop" call outs within the posts. The content on the Instagram account uses similar aspirational, tidy and very distant language compared to content from the Rolex brand.

Rolex's ambassador strategy acts as the foundation of the brand's social narrative through partnerships with individuals like Roger Federer and Tiger Woods. These partnerships communicate a sporting value or excellence as well as a collaborative value. In motorsport, Rolex also maintains its place as the Official Timepiece of the IMSA Championship and the Rolex 24 at Daytona by leveraging that exposure to help create broadcast integration and generate organic social amplification without needing to post high-frequency content.

Interestingly, Rolex also benefits from a huge earned media ecosystem that it has not created. The seriousness around the steel Daytona and Submariner models (which have documented resale value at approximately 50-100% above retail price) has generated hundreds of thousands of organic video posts on TikTok, tens of thousands of YouTube channels, hundreds of thousands of Reddit threads and Instagram accounts relating to collectability, waitlist strategies and unboxing experiences.

1.2 TAG Heuer: The Strategy of Velocity and Volume

TAG Heuer has a distinctively different approach. As a subsidiary of LVMH, TAG Heuer will benefit from a reported \$1 billion, ten-year sponsorship agreement (2025 – 2035) as the official timekeeper for Formula 1, replacing Rolex, who had been the official timekeeper for over a decade. Due to this, TAG Heuer has positioned social media as a front-line growth driver instead of a marketing asset to protect brand longevity.

TAG Heuer is active on Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, Facebook, and X, where TAG Heuer posts at a significantly higher frequency than most of its modern luxury competitors. TAG Heuer's activity on TikTok consists mostly of short-format video series connected to race weekends, behind-the-scenes moments during the F1 paddock, and driver moments. These activities in short format are designed to complement the key success metrics demanded by the TikTok algorithm: Completion Rate, Shareability, and Using Trending Audio. TAG Heuer's Chief Marketing Officer, George Ciz, shared in early 2025 that the brand's engagement on Instagram,

behind only Rolex, will rank second among watch brands worldwide; by 2023, TAG Heuer will have achieved the rank of first among all watch brands globally.

Furthermore, TAG Heuer has been very active in using Influencers as a marketing tool targeting Gen Z & younger millennials, working with creators from both lifestyle and motorsport platforms, as opposed to working solely with elite celebrity ambassadors. The TAG Heuer brand has also developed a pricing strategy that allows it to position itself in between Rolex and Omega, by offering what they refer to as "affordable luxury" (with most models priced at less than £5,000) enabling social channels to serve a direct customer acquisition function for TAG Heuer watches, which is not typically the case with Rolex watches since there is no direct link between social reach & actual purchase. With the TAG Heuer Connected smart watch line, TAG Heuer will also reach new technology oriented consumers (who typically do not purchase luxury watches) on TikTok & other social platforms.

2. Critical Comparative Evaluation

2.1 Engagement Quality and Follower Growth

Metric	Rolex	TAG Heuer
Instagram Followers	~18 million (@rolex)	#1 in engagement Jan 2025 (ahead of Rolex)
Instagram Rank (by engagement)	Strong but declining relative to peers	Rose from #7 (2021) to #1 (Jan 2025)
TikTok Presence	No official brand account; vast organic ecosystem	Active; F1 race content, influencer partnerships
Content Frequency	Very low; ~1,790 posts total on Instagram	High; race-week surge cadence
Primary Content Type	Cinematic video, ambassador imagery	Short-form F1, influencer UGC, lifestyle reels

TAG Heuer's growth in engagement is impressive based on empirical data. Digital Luxury Group's benchmarking shows it as the 'fastest-growing brand year-on-year in 2024'. TAG Heuer's growth prior to activating the F1 deal implies this may be symptomatic of a wider strategic change at TAG Heuer under CEO Antoine Pin, who has allocated almost 20% of sales for marketing expenditure in 2025. The F1 partnership has created an ongoing content engine through 24 races taking place around the world, giving TAG Heuer ample opportunity to post at a high frequency and urgency without it appearing to be forced or unnatural.

On the other hand, Rolex's engagement level is characterized by its 'signal-to-noise' ratio: much fewer posts accumulate greater overall impact because the audience has been conditioned to consider all of the posts as 'events' instead of 'post feed' items. TAG Heuer has traded intensity for growth whereas Rolex has traded volume for intensity.

2.2 Framework Application: IDEACT and Content Marketing Theory

The IDEACT (Identify, Design, Engage, Act, Convert, Track) framework illustrates areas of success for each of the brands as well as where there are gaps.

Rolex demonstrates a strong Identify (precise audience segmentation across collectors of watches, purchasers of milestone product and aspirational high net worth purchasers), strong Design (the brand has an outstanding quality; it employs a cinematic brand identity with strict consistency), and strong Engage (through ambassador narratives, and sponsorship integrated with their ambassadors). Rolex intentionally and purposefully does not perform well in the categories of Act and Convert; they do not have a "shop now" button or link in their bio for commerce, nor do they provide a conversion journey for a purchase from a post. Regarding the Track discipline, Rolex does not release any information for its metrics or analytics, and their low posting frequency suggests that they optimize their posts for brand equity metrics rather than click-through or conversions.

TAG Heuer performs well in all disciplines of the IDEACT framework, with particular strengths in Act (making the most of the virality from F1 race moments), Convert (the TAG Heuer Connected watch creates a lower price point for entry into the brand, allowing for viable social to purchase journeys), and Track (understandably, the CMO monitors platform rankings to benchmark their activity against others). TAG Heuer's Design category has a weakness; their content aesthetic is varying across multiple platforms, and posting at a high frequency may result in the dilution of luxury codes over time.

2.3 Alignment with Organisational Objectives

Rolex brands use social media to manage desire, maintain a culture of waiting, create a sense of urgency when purchasing their products, and enhance Rolex as a luxury brand by using a combination of creating aspirations through images or video yet providing no outlet for making a purchase. The purpose 'Not having a "buy now" button on their website is not a mistake', but rather it is the way in which they use social media to create a perception of high perceived value.

TAG Heuer focuses on expanding its market share and reaching more demographic groups. CEO Antoine Pin has specifically stated that TAG Heuer plans to increase sales volume, including making the products more affordable through the introduction of new designs. The partnership with Formula 1 (F1) serves not only as a means for brand enhancement but also as a way to attract customers.

Both approaches may have benefits or disadvantages depending on the business model being followed by the respective watch brands. For example, Rolex would be in a dodgy position if it were to increase its followers through trendy content. On the other hand, TAG Heuer may be in trouble if it were to avoid using social media like Rolex because it would lose the opportunity to capitalize on the momentum created from its partnership with F1 sponsorship.

2.4 Paid vs. Organic Tactics

Rolex has an organic feel. The lack of paid social amplification in owned channels is outweighed by the earned media from sponsoring broadcasts. Thus giving Rolex a signal of luxury positioning: brands that pay to show in feeds suggest either have a scarcity of product, while brands that are spoken about on an organic basis suggest that their product has cultural currency.

TAG Heuer integrates paid and organic strategies to create a cohesive approach. TAG Heuer's investment in F1 partnership provides funding for both institutional brand building, such as the pit lane clock and the Monaco watch display in the paddock, as well as infrastructure for content creation (behind the scenes at races with access for creator content). The LVMH context also provides an opportunity for cross-promoting: the 2025 F1 season has had coordinated activations (Louis Vuitton, Moët and Chandon and TAG Heuer), which each brand has amplified due to the cumulative LVMH social style.

3. Lessons Learned

3.1 Best Practices Worth Replicating

Rolex - Scarcity as a Social Signal: The key takeaway with Rolex is that they are communicating through restraint as a brand. Low frequency of posting, high production quality and lack of participation in social media trends all serve as luxury signals to a digitally-savvy audience. For all companies operating in premium categories, there is an opportunity for the brand to communicate value through scarcity; therefore, companies should limit the frequency of their posts when the brand's overall proposition relies on the perception of scarcity. The example of Rolex underscores organic ecosystems can communicate the brand message much more effectively than any owned posting calendar could.

TAG Heuer - Partnerships as Content Sources: The F1 sponsorship demonstrates that when a sponsorship is carefully aligned with the brand's target audience and heritage, it can be the solution to the most difficult social media challenge; providing a constant supply of authentic and engaging content. Rather than simply creating their own brand narrative in a vacuum, TAG Heuer has established itself in partnership with the world's fastest-growing club sport. The message itself has not changed since the launch of F1 but brands need to seek out partnerships to use as "content calendars" not simply as logo placements.

3.2 Pitfalls and Ineffective Approaches

TAG Heuer is most at risk from losing brand identity via brand dilution. According to benchmarking data from Socialinsider (2021), TikTok has a significantly higher engagement rate of 3.70% than Instagram's 0.48%. The high volume of engagement on TikTok does not equal high value for TAG Heuer's luxury class product. The algorithm that TikTok uses to surface content to non-followers creates a reach through organic exposure; however, this does not translate as deep as how TAG Heuer has created community-based exclusive relationships to establish brand value. Therefore, viral moments on TikTok and how the content is falling to meet the completion rate and sharing metrics can undermine TAG Heuer's Netscape defined images, which separate them from mass market offerings.

The potential pitfall for Rolex is the opposite of what they currently have, which is a lack of engaging with the next generation of luxury buyers in the channels they use to develop brand familiarity. Research online, purchase offline (ROPO) is the new normal even for HNWIs (high-net-worth individuals). Additionally, Gen Z and younger millennials are increasingly turning to TikTok to search and discover new brands. Rolex's organic ecosystem relies on outside forces who do not answer to them, such as resellers, grey market dealers and speculators, to define the brand narrative in those environments. This may not only be a reach limitation but also a risk to their reputation.

3.3 Strategic Insights and Industry Trends

The comparison between Rolex and TAG Heuer illustrates a broader issue in the way luxury brands use social media for marketing purposes, namely, luxury brands often struggle to balance accessibility (which helps to drive follower growth, engagement and ultimately conversion) with mystery (which helps to sustain price premiums, secondary market price premiums and aspiration). According to Kapferer and Bastien's luxury paradox, luxury brands must be known in order to be desired, yet cannot be available in order to be desired; therefore, social media exacerbates this contradiction by design.

An important trend within luxury brands is moving towards using sports sponsorships as the foundational infrastructure for social content. For example, LVMH has built a multi-brand Formula 1 sponsorship because they recognise that elite sports, particularly those with large global digital audiences, enable luxury brands to create a legitimised context for creating high-frequency and high-visibility content. This type of content would normally compromise a luxury brand's exclusivity codes; however, Formula 1's record on social media (with 2.3 billion engagements in 2025) is demonstrating that the return on investment from sports sponsorships far exceeds traditional advertising metrics.

Simply measuring the number of followers is not an accurate measure of a brand's health; engagement metrics, earned media value and share of voice in regard to their relevant competitive set will provide much more actionable strategic insights than simply measuring the number of followers.

3.4 Conclusion

TAG Heuer and Rolex provide an informative contrast where one model is not necessarily right or wrong but both are internally consistent with their commercial models. Rolex's social media strategy is a continuation of their product strategy, which builds desire through scarcity, silence, and selectivity. TAG Heuer's social media strategy is a continuation of their growth goals, which seek to achieve reach, relevance, and conversion through volume, partnerships and platform nativity. The key strategic differentiation is that for Rolex social media serves to amplify an already existing aura, while for TAG Heuer social media itself is a part of the aura-building process. As the luxury sector seeks to make sense of an ever-increasingly noisy digital environment, the question for any brand entering this space is "What do we want our social presence to mean?". The two brands demonstrate that the answer will be more influenced by an understanding of what scarcity means to your buyer, than by platform mechanics.

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